From DM to Booked

Turning "hey, how much for a silk press?" into a confirmed appointment — before the thread goes cold.

A Miko Pierson playbook · Bigger Than Shears™

A DM is not a conversation — it is a booking in progress.

Every month, hundreds of millions of people message businesses on Instagram alone. Most of those messages are one of two questions — *how much* or *are you free* — asked at the exact moment interest peaks. What happens in the next five minutes decides whether that's a client or a ghost. The research on lead response is brutal about the window: the odds of qualifying a lead collapse within the first hour, and businesses that answer in under five minutes convert several times better than the ones who answer tonight.

The three moves

1. Answer inside the window — with a saved reply, not a novel

You cannot handcraft a response to every DM between clients. You don't have to:

- Build three saved replies: **price range**, **availability link**, **consultation ask**. Instagram's quick-reply feature covers the questions that make up a third or more of inbound DMs.
- Your first reply does two jobs in two sentences — answers their question, and moves them one step: *"Hi! Silk press starts at $85 — I can check your timing right here. What week were you thinking?"*
- Answered-in-five-minutes beats perfectly-answered-tomorrow. Every hour the thread sits, it's colder.

2. Pre-answer the two questions

The reason DMs stall: the client has to ask what your content should have said.

- **Price:** put a starting-price range in your bio or services highlights — "cuts from $60, color from $120." Range is enough; they need a ballpark, not a quote.
- **Availability:** a highlighted story called "This Week" with real open slots beats twenty minutes of back-and-forth.

- Most buyers now say they'd rather research than talk — let the quiet ones pre-answer themselves, and the DM arrives already warm.

3. One link. Three taps.

This is where most bookings die — not in the DM, in the path after it:

- **One link in bio**, going straight to a booking page. Not a Linktree with nine choices — every extra option is a tap where someone drops.
- **Three taps to booked:** bio → see real open times → confirm. If the flow needs an account created first, a long form, or scrolling a 40-item service menu to guess what's bookable — you built the exit.
- Inside the DM, don't describe the booking — *drop the link*: *"Here's my book — pick whatever works: [link]. If you want help choosing, I'm right here."*

The honest boundary

DMs convert because they feel personal — keep the personal in them. Automate the repetitive answers (price, link, hours) so you can be human where it counts: the consult, the "will this work for my hair," the rebook. The system answers the easy questions instantly; you answer the ones that build the relationship.

And if a thread goes quiet? That's not a lost client — it's a follow-up cadence (see *The Follow-Up That Isn't Pushy*).

Your DMs are already a booking channel — they just don't have a floor plan yet. Which part of yours leaks first: the speed, the answers, or the link?

Sources: Meta business messaging data (platform-published); Oldroyd/MIT lead-response study (contact odds collapse 100×, qualify 21×, 5→30 min); HBR lead-response audit (within-1-hour = 7× qualification; avg response 42 hrs); social-DM response benchmarks (<5 min converts ~3× — vendor-aggregated); booking-flow abandonment research (account creation is a top drop-off driver); Salonnare/Ekada 3-tap booking analyses; HubSpot 2024 Consumer Trends (self-serve research preference). Platform and vendor figures are directionally consistent — flagged as platform-published where Meta is the source.